



Family Nursing
& Home Care

Customer Service Communications Guidelines



The purpose of these guidelines is to provide the best possible service to all clients, service users both internal and external. All departmental communications must be conducted in a professional and courteous manner, responsive to the needs of the internal and external customer.

FACE TO FACE COMMUNICATION

The purpose of home visiting is to build a positive relationship with the patient/client/family. Four important components of successful home visiting are communicating with skill and heart, empathy, understanding non-verbal communication, and listening well.

1. Communicating with skill and warmth

- Giving adequate wait time
- No interrupting
- Listening carefully then responding appropriately

2. Empathy

- Coming to a deeper understanding of another person's situation by looking at it through his or her perspective or experiences.

3. Understanding non-verbal communication

- Sometimes the words we speak are less significant in communicating ideas than our expressions and stance.
- Facial expressions, body posture, awareness of personal space, and intuition all play a vital role in understanding.
- Confusion can be the result of unfamiliarity with the other person's cultural norms.

4. Listening

- Working effectively with patients/families requires good questions and even better listening skills.

To gain trust we have to build rapport

Face to Face

Words	7%
Tone	38%
Body Language	55%

How to prepare for a home visit

Think about your goals for this visit and make a plan. Will you need to prepare materials or information? Schedule the home visit ahead of time.

How to respectfully enter the home

Be prepared for the visit with goals in mind and any needed materials.

Introduce yourself and explain the purpose of your visit.

Establish the focus of the visit.

Stay safe

Listen to your intuition. If a situation doesn't feel safe, leave.

Follow-up

Carry through promptly on any promises or agreements made during the visit.

Record notes about your visit so you remember what was discussed.

TELEPHONE COMMUNICATION

All telephone calls should be answered promptly and in a professional and courteous manner in accordance with these guidelines.

Guidelines for the Telephone

Answering the telephone is every employee's responsibility throughout FNHC. As a general rule, telephones should be answered within three (3) rings and it becomes each employee's job to answer it.

When answering the telephone, use a friendly, professional manner. Our greeting is the first thing heard by callers, you are setting an example and making the first impression for the department. Speak distinctly, with a warm welcoming tone. Let your caller know which office he or she is talking with, by identifying the division and telling him or her your name. Imagine that you are the caller, and answer in the way that you would want to be treated.

Rapport

To gain trust we have to build rapport

Telephone

Words 18%

Tone 82%

Here are sample greetings to use when answering office lines:

Good Morning. Family Nursing & Home Care, Jane Smith speaking. May I help you?"

"Family Nursing & Home Care, Child & Family Services. May I help you?"

"Good Morning. District Nursing Servicing, Jane Doe. May I help you?"

"Good Morning" ,Finance Department, Jane Smith speaking, can I help you."

Sometimes callers are in a hurry. They may interrupt you and seem rude. You should remain cool, friendly and cooperative.

Become a better listener. Stop talking and focus your attention on the caller. Avoid distractions. Concentrate on what the other person is saying. Show interest and concern to the reason for the call.

Find out what the caller needs. Don't be afraid to ask the caller questions to find out his or her concerns. Do not needlessly transfer the person because you did not listen to his/her question or problem. If you have determined you are not the person they should talk to, apologize to the caller and briefly explain why you are unable to assist him or her.

Make sure you have the caller's approval before transferring the caller to the appropriate person. Give the caller the correct telephone number and the person's name to which you are transferring him or

Here is a sample response:

"Ms. Smith, I am really sorry you are having a problem regarding your appointment, however, I am not the person you should talk to about this issue. I do know whom you should talk to and if it is all right with you, I am going to transfer you to her. So that you have the correct information, her number is 44xxx and her name is Susie Doe."

Putting Callers "On Hold"

The telephone should never be answered with an immediate request for the caller to hold. Always ask the caller first if he or she minds holding and wait for his or her reply. When you initially put a caller on hold, never leave him or her on hold for more than thirty seconds.

Here is a sample greeting to use in this type of situation:

"District Nursing Services. Do you mind holding?"

When getting back with the caller, who is on hold, always thank the caller for his or her patience. If you need to research information for the caller's inquiry, give him or her the option to either hold or you will get back with the caller when you have obtained the information. If the caller chooses to remain on hold, two minutes on hold is the maximum amount of time without returning to the caller for updates. If the caller prefers that you call him or her back, indicate the timeframe in which the caller may expect your call. Always thank the caller for waiting and use the person's name

Here are samples:

"Thank you for waiting." or "I really appreciate your patience, Ms. Smith."

"I will need to check out that information for you. Do you mind holding for a few minutes or would you prefer I call you back?"

Transferring Calls

Callers should not be transferred directly to a voice mailbox without first asking the caller if that's okay. Give the caller the correct telephone number and the name of the person to whom he or she should talk. Briefly explain to the caller why you are unable to assist him or her yourself.

Here is a sample response:

"The person you need to speak with is Jane Smith and she is not in her office right now. I can transfer you to her voice mailbox so you can leave her a message. Let me give you her phone number so you will have it."

If the call is for someone else and you find that the person being called is not available, DO NOT put a call through directly to a voice mailbox without first talking to the caller and asking if that is what he/she wants to do.

Here is a sample response:

"Jane Smith isn't in her office right now, but I'll be glad to transfer you to her voice mailbox or I will take a message."

Dealing with more challenging individuals

Sometimes we may have to deal with difficult individuals, that may be upset and shouting. It may be that the person is in pain, desperate for help or angry. When dealing with these individuals we must:

- Listen without interrupting
- Do not get defensive – be open
- Respond with sorry, absolutely, definitely
- Express empathy
- Ask open questions and show understanding
- Explain what you can do
- Agree an action plan – this may include signposting to other staff with a full explanation
- Implement the action plan
- Follow up to ensure customer satisfaction

Using an Effective Handover Tool

When handing over messages and requests to colleagues using the SBAR as a tool ensures that you have the right information and are able to assess and recommend your actions.

SITUATION

Your name, client's name, succinct overview of pertinent issues

BACKGROUND

Who or what request is concerning, along with concise, relevant background to request/problem

ASSESSMENT

Summarise and give the best assessment

RECOMMENDATION

What do you want to happen next? What actions are you asking for?

CLIENT FEEDBACK

Let the client know what is happening.

VOICE MAIL COMMUNICATION

Voice mail personal greetings shall be professional, kept current, and updated when necessary. Personal greetings shall indicate the staff member's name, position, frequency with which messages will be checked, and a provision for contacting someone in person. Voice mail shall be checked frequently and calls shall be returned promptly.

Guidelines for Voice Mail

Voice mail can be a valuable tool if used correctly. Used incorrectly, it may cause anxiety and even anger. The system can be the caller's first and last impression of FNHC.

Voice mail is designed to ensure that callers do not become frustrated but receive prompt and quality customer service. Instead of getting a busy signal or no answer, the caller can leave a message in voice mail and from the personal greeting will know when to expect a call back or be given an option to speak to someone else.

Personal Greetings

Your personal greeting for your voice mailbox should be current and updated daily. It should tell callers when you're going to be out of the office and unable to return phone calls. Let callers know when you will return calls and always give them an option of someone else whom they may call.

Personal greetings shall indicate the staff member's name and provide any relevant information you would like if you were the caller. An option for reaching a live person should be stated.

Speak clearly and make your greetings friendly but professional.

Here are some sample personal greetings:

"This is Jane Smith from District Nursing Services. I'll be out of the office until September 3rd. If you want to leave a message, I will be glad to return your call then. But if you need immediate assistance, please call John Smith at extension 44xxx in my office and he will be glad to help you."

"This is Jane Smith in the District Nursing Department, I will not be in the office until after 1pm today. You can redial 44xxx if you don't want to leave a voice mail message, however I will check my messages and return phone calls after this time. Please leave your name, number and details."

Your voice mailbox should be checked frequently for messages and it should never fill up. It is your responsibility to check your messages and to change your greeting to reflect your schedule.

Always return phone calls promptly. Callers may get very frustrated when they leave a message and do not receive a response in a timely manner. If the caller's message will require a lengthy follow-up but you don't immediately have the time and/or the answer, place a short phone call to let him/her know that you have received the message and will call back to talk more fully later.

Let other staff members know when you will be out of the office, especially for extended periods of time. This will prevent staff members from transferring a caller to your voice mail.

WRITTEN COMMUNICATION

Communication in the form of a letter shall be written in a professional and courteous manner. The written response to internal or external correspondence shall be clear, informative and timely. The response shall be done in accordance with the guidelines for written communication.

Guidelines for Written Communication

Written communication can be a very effective way to respond to internal and external customers. Care should be taken to ensure that all responses provide the appropriate information to the customer and that the FNHC employees are accountable for the quality of service that is provided.

Letters should be written in a professional format with the standard style, font and size used by FNHC. All letters should be proof read carefully, not only for spelling and punctuation, but also for consistency and accuracy.

The appropriate letterhead for FNHC should be used. The letter should include the following: date, recipient's complete name and address and the response in the body of the letter, the complimentary closing, typed signature (Name and Job title, and the "enclosure" or "attachment" and "copy - cc:" (if applicable).

The final paragraph of the letter should include a person's name and telephone number to call if additional information is needed or if the recipient has more questions.

ELECTRONIC MAIL (E-MAIL) COMMUNICATION

Communication via e-mail shall be conducted in a professional and courteous manner. The e-mail response shall be clear, informative and timely. The response shall be written in accordance with the FNHC's Email Policy.

E-mail can be another very effective and quick communication method to use when corresponding with internal and external customers. The FNHC Email policy is designed to ensure that all e-mail messages are handled appropriately and that FNHC employees are accountable for the quality of services provided.

Communicate in a professional manner when using the e-mail system. Never put anything in an e-mail message that would be viewed as offensive or inappropriate for the business environment. Remember that all information contained in the e-mail message may be required as part of Subject Access Request.

The e-mail response should give complete and clear information with the option to use e-mail or call if there are questions. A letter format with a subject heading and a complimentary closing should always be used when responding to inquiries. Always check for spelling, punctuation, and formatting errors prior to sending the e-mail message. Care should also be taken to ensure that all responses provide the appropriate information to the customer by checking for consistency and accuracy.

Your electronic mailbox should be checked frequently for messages. It is your responsibility to always check your electronic mailbox for messages just like you check your voice mailbox. Always read your e-mail messages very carefully and respond in a timely manner. People may get frustrated when they send an e-mail message expecting a response and don't receive a response back within an appropriate timeframe.

If you don't have an immediate answer and/or it may require a lengthier follow-up than normal, acknowledge receipt of the e-mail message, but note that you need additional time to research and respond.

If the e-mail message requires a response from someone else, acknowledge that you have received the e-mail message and note that you are going to forward it to the appropriate person who should handle the request. Include the person's name and e-mail address in your e-mail response. Always include a closing sentence in your e-mail message, giving them options to contact you if he or she needs additional assistance.

When you are away from your office longer than a normal timeframe, your e-mail should reflect that schedule. Using the 'Out of Office' facility, you should enter an automatic reply that states your schedule.

Here is a sample message:

"I will be out of my office from 1st July 2015 – 7th July 2015, but I will be happy to respond when I return, however if you need assistance before I return on July 7th, please e-mail Sue Smith at her e-mail address, sue.smith@fnhc.org.je, or call her on 44xxxx

Top tips for great customer service

- 1) The person who is the most flexible is their thinking and their behaviour will have the most control and influence over any interaction.
- 2) You can only change YOUR thinking and behaviour and NEVER the client's.
- 3) Make eye contact more when you are listening than when you are speaking.
- 4) Answer the phone with a greeting, your name, workplace and an offer of help.
- 5) Always start the response to a request with "what I can do for your is" never "sorry that's not possible" or "I can't".
- 6) Confirm every agreed plan/appointment by repeating back to check understanding.
- 7) If you say you will phone someone back, always do do before you leave your shift, even if you have nothing to update them on. This is how you build trust.
- 8) Always ask the client on the phone if they would mind holding rather than just putting them on hold, wait for their response.
- 9) Great customer service is only as good as the weakest person on your team, therefore TEAMWORK is the key.
- 10) Remember that you filter information more through your tone and physiology than your words.